Official Pickleball Rules and Governance (2023)

I. Governance and Standards

USA Pickleball continues as the national governing body for the sport in the United States, providing the official rules to maintain the integrity and consistent growth of the game [cite: 1, 2]. The 2023 rules prioritize clarity for players, officials, and tournament directors across all skill levels [cite: 3]. The mission remains focused on promoting the sport's core values while adapting to its rapid global expansion [cite: 2].

II. Equipment & Court Layout

Court dimensions are maintained at 20 feet wide by 44 feet long ($6.10m \times 13.41m$) for both singles and doubles play [cite: 1, 2]. The net height is 36 inches at the posts and 34 inches at the center [cite: 1, 2]. The 7-foot Non-Volley Zone (NVZ) is a fundamental court element designed to prevent players from executing smashes directly at the net [cite: 1, 2]. Ball specifications require 26 to 40 circular holes, and paddles must meet USAPA material and surface roughness standards [cite: 1, 2].

III. Service Rules and Key 2023 Changes

Traditional Volley Serve

The server must hit the ball underhand, with the paddle contact occurring below the waist [cite: 1, 2]. The server’s arm must move in an upward arc, and the highest point of the paddle head must be below the wrist [cite: 1, 2].

The Spin Serve Ban

A major update for 2023 is the complete prohibition of 'spin serves' where the server uses their hand to manipulate the ball to create spin before the strike [cite: 1, 2]. The ball must be released from the hand in a natural manner without any added spin [cite: 1, 2]. The 'Drop Serve' remains a legal alternative, provided the ball is dropped and allowed to bounce naturally before being struck [cite: 1, 2].

IV. Gameplay: Scoring and Faults

Scoring remains 'side-out' scoring, meaning only the serving team can earn points [cite: 1, 2]. Matches are typically played to 11 points, winning by 2 [cite: 1, 2]. The Two-Bounce Rule is strictly enforced: the ball must bounce once on each side before any player may volley

[cite: 1, 2]. It is a fault if a player touches the NVZ or its lines during a volley or as a result of momentum following a volley [cite: 1, 2].

V. Sportsmanship and Officiating

The 2023 rulebook places a strong emphasis on sportsmanship and fair play [cite: 1, 2]. Players are responsible for making their own line calls and reporting faults honestly in non-officiated matches [cite: 1, 2]. Tournament Directors and certified referees oversee sanctioned play to ensure adherence to these official standards [cite: 2, 3].